

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only kind new ideas to try.

Before you begin

It is festival day in the Lantern Village. All morning the market has been getting ready, with stalls of paper fans, baskets of fruit, and rows of glowing lanterns. But oh dear. Pon the Tanuki was so excited that he bounced and rolled right through the market, and he knocked every stall over by mistake. Now the fans, the fruit, and the lanterns are all in one big jumble, and Pon feels terrible.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her. "You two have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you help Pon set the market right before the festival opens?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red thread, a little bell, and a sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Wisdom, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1: The Jumbled Stalls

You hurry to the market and find Pon the Tanuki sitting in the middle of the mess. His ears droop. His nose wobbles. "I have spoiled everything," he sniffs. "I only wanted to help."

He is too upset to tidy up. He needs a kind word first.

What could you do to help Pon feel better? You could sit beside him. You could tell him it was an accident. You could say that everyone can fix a muddle together. What do you try?

When you are kind to Pon, he wipes his nose and gives a little smile. "You are good friends," he says. "Let us tidy up together." And he jumps up, ready to help.

Stop 2: The Great Sort

Now you look at the jumble. Fans, fruit, and lanterns are all mixed up in one big heap. Everything must go back to the right stall before the festival opens.

The fans belong on the fan stall. The fruit belongs in the fruit baskets. The lanterns belong on the lantern posts. You will need to sort them, and count them, and match them up.

How will you sort it all out? Could you make a pile for each kind of thing? Could you count the lanterns onto the posts? Could you match the fruit by its colour? What is your plan?

When you sort and count it all back into place, the market begins to look right again. Pon claps his paws. "You are so clever!" he says.

Stop 3: The Last Lantern

The market is nearly perfect. But one lantern is still missing: the big red festival lantern that hangs over the very middle of the market. Without it, the festival cannot begin.

Then Kon the Fox trots out of the bamboo. "I saw something round and red roll under the plum tree by the bridge," he says with a wink. "Follow my clue."

Where could the last lantern be? Could you follow Kon's clue to the plum tree? Could you ask Pon to help you look? What do you do?

You follow the clue and there it is, the big red lantern, safe under the plum tree. You carry it back and hang it high. "I found the spot it rolled to," says Pon proudly. "I helped after all." And he stands a little taller.

The Festival Opens

The market is set right at last. Every fan is fanned out, every basket of fruit is neat, and every lantern glows warm in its place, with the big red one shining in the middle.

Pon the Tanuki is forgiven, and best of all, he is proud. The drum begins to beat, the people come laughing into the square, and the festival opens at last.

High above, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were wise, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes of the Lantern Village.

The Story in Pictures



A jolly round tanuki looking worried among toppled festival stalls with fruit, fans and lanterns jumbled together, two small heroes arriving.



Two small heroes and a happy tanuki sorting festival goods back into the right stalls, counting fans and fruit and lanterns into neat rows.



A friendly fox offering a clue to two small heroes searching for one last lost festival lantern among blossom trees.



A tidy festival market all set right at dusk, neat stalls and glowing lanterns, a happy tanuki and two small heroes admiring it together.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 2, updated 2026-06-03, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.